

layers as you would place images drawn on butter paper! The one on top is the one that's always visible, and each layer below will appear behind the one on top. So make sure your background is always the layer that's at the bottom, and then pile on the layers from there. You can change the order in which the layers are placed simply by holding down the left mouse button on a layer and dragging it up or down, depending on how you want to place it. Alternatively, you can just use the following keyboard shortcuts:

Action	Shortcut
Bring Forward (move layer up)	[Ctrl] + “[”
Bring To Front (move layer on top)	[Ctrl] + [Shift] + “[”
Send Backward (move layer down)	[Ctrl] + “]”
Send To Back (move layer to bottom)	[Ctrl] + [Shift] + “]”

Here “[” is the square bracket open key, and “]” is the square bracket close key.

Layer Blending Modes

At the top-left corner of the Layers palette, you can choose a *Layer Blending Mode*, which determines how the layer will interact with the ones below it. You can create some really cool effects with these, as well as use them for more “proper” purposes like photo retouching. By default, the layer blending mode is Normal, which means that the layer won't interact with any of the others.

Of course, in images that have, say, 40 or more layers, all the naming conventions in the world will not help! That's where layer groups come in...

4.4 Grouping Layers

Many complex Photoshop works of art have more layers than Bill Gates has \$100 bills! Yes, we're not kidding, some PSDs that our designers right here at *Digit* work with have hundreds of layers. If it weren't for Photoshop's layer feature called Groups, all designers would be bald from tearing their own hair out! Actually, most are already getting there, but that's a story for another time!